



What are Big Ideas?

- Are *concepts, themes, debates, pardozes, questions, theories, and/or principles* considered central or *fundamental* to a *discipline*.
- They provide a **framework** for the **long-term development** of **student understanding**.
- Provide a foundation on which future, more specialized learning can build.
- Moves course redesign **away from activity based** to **concept based** planning
- Provides a **common cognitive focus** for **ALL** learners



How do I determine Big Ideas in my domain?

- What are the things do I hope my students will remember and be able to apply long after they have forgotten specific bits of factual information?
- **Ex:** Size Dependent Properties
 - **Big Idea Statement:** The properties of matter can change with scale. In particular, during the transition between the bulk material and individual atoms or molecules.



To Be a Big Idea

- The statement must **have more than two examples**
- It must be an enduring understanding , **NOT** a detail
- It must be able to complete the sentence prompt, “ **I want my students to understand that..**”



Let's Practice

Directions: Identify the sentence that would be considered a Big Idea

1. Plants and animals are interdependent.
2. Egyptians constructed pyramids and mummified their dead
3. Bees pollinate flowers as they collect nectar to make honey.
4. Authors choose a genre according to the message they want to send
5. Pueblo people lived in houses made out of adobe



Let's Practice

1. **Plants and animals are interdependent.**
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Activity: Big Ideas in your Domain

Learning Outcome: At the end of this activity instructors will identify several big ideas for their domain, to support their course redesign.

Directions:

1. In your course team identify the big ideas in your domain.
2. We recognize that these big ideas may not be agreed upon by all individuals in your department, but please develop them based on the consensus within your team.
3. Number each big idea and provide a brief statement explaining finishing the following statement:

“I want students to understand that...”

Example:

Big Idea 1: Structures of Matter

Statement : I want students to understand that materials consist of building blocks that often form a hierarchy of structures. Atoms interact with each other to form molecules. The next higher level of organization involves atoms, molecules, or nanoscale structures interacting with each other to form nanoscale assemblies and structures.